for the construction of the Shri Ram Temple'. The Modi government, he stressed, 'has rectified the historical mistakes after Independence'.[67] Similarly, Shah argued in his first speech as party president to the BJP's National Council that 'for almost six decades, society was influenced essentially on the basis of the Congress ideology. In fact, politics was over-shadowed by a Congress culture. Now, it is our duty that our ideology should positively influence the thinking and work culture of our society.'[68] For a leader who sees the BJP's ideological differentiation as its life-force, and who has played a fundamental role in reorganising and expanding the party's organisational machinery, one thing is certain: there can be no softening on the BJP's core issues.

In the party's second tier, Yogi Adityanath (born 1972) has long been the leader most in demand for election rallies, after Modi and Shah. Modi became the BJP's prime ministerial candidate in 2013 on the back of his 'Gujarat model'. He came to Delhi after a decade as chief minister in one of India's most prosperous states, one that was also the original 'laboratory' of Hindutva. Gujarat remains Modi's citadel, but his ascent to power was made possible by the party's breakthrough in UP, which delivered seventy-one (25.1 per cent) BJP MPs in 2014 and sixty-two (20.4 per cent) in 2019. Modi himself fronted the UP breakthrough, contesting from the ancient city of Varanasi in both parliamentary elections. He also fronted the 2017 UP assembly election campaign, which resulted in a BJP sweep and Adityanath's ascent to power in Lucknow.

Undoubtedly, the political road to Delhi runs through Lucknow. Yogi Adityanath is already the BJP's most nationally visible chief minister. If he retains UP in the 2022 assembly elections, he will emerge as the most influential party chief minister. He has age on his side, and many years of politics ahead of him. He, like Modi in his chief-ministerial avatar, is a political lightning rod whose very presence sharply polarises opinion. His ideological facade is even harder than that of the Modi–Shah combine. Crucially, no individual UP chief minister has ever been returned to power for back-to-back terms since Independence. If Yogi does it in 2022, he will have a power base like none other in the BJP, with at least two decades of politics still ahead of him.